Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics Audit

In this audit, I will navigate the interface independently, take screenshots of flaws I find, assign Nielsen Usability heuristic(s) to the problems I identify, and assign a severity rating from 0-4.

Before we begin, here are the 10 heuristics listed in order that i will be referring to by number and the scale for the severity ratings:

The 10 Usability Heuristics

Heuristic	Core Concept	Example
Visibility of System Status	Keep users informed about what is happening through appropriate feedback within a reasonable time.	Progress bars during file uploads or continuous "Saving..." indicators in Google Docs.
Match Between System & Real World	Use words, concepts, and conventions familiar to the user rather than internal system jargon.	Using a physical trash can icon for deleting files or calling a digital reader's mark a "bookmark."
User Control & Freedom	Provide a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave unwanted states without an extended process.	The Undo (Ctrl+Z) function, back buttons, or a clear "Cancel" option in multi-step dialogs.
Consistency & Standards	Follow platform conventions so users don't wonder whether different words or actions mean the same thing.	Placing the main navigation bar at the top or left of a site, or making links blue and underlined.
Error Prevention	Either eliminate error-prone conditions or check for them and offer users a confirmation before committing.	Confirmation prompts before permanent deletion ("Are you sure?"), or disabling "Submit" until forms are valid.
Recognition Rather than Recall	Minimize memory load by making objects, actions, and options visible instead of forcing users to remember.	Dropdown menus with options shown, recent search history suggestions, or visual thumbnails.
Flexibliity & Efficiceny of Use	Tailor experience for both inexperienced and experienced users with accelerators like keyboard shortcuts.	Ctrl+C / Ctrl+V for quick copy-pasting, macro automations, or customizable dashboard layouts.
Aesthetic & Minimalist Design	Interfaces should not contain irrelevant or rarely needed information, as extra clutter competes with vital content.	Google Search's minimalist homepage focus versus cluttered web portals from the late 1990s.
Help Users Recognize & Recover from Errors	Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no codes), precisely indicate the problem, and suggest a fix.	"Password must contain at least 8 characters" instead of showing Error 0x80004005.
Help & Documentation	Even if a system is usable without docs, easy-to-search assistance with concrete steps should be available.	Tooltips on hover, searchable FAQ sections, or step-by-step onboarding tours for new features.

3. Severity Rating
    - Assign a standard 0–4 scale to prioritize the fixes:
        - 0: not a usability problem
        - 1: cosmetic problem only (fix if time permits)
        - 2: minor usability problem (low priority)
        - 3: major usability problem (important to fix)
        - 4: Usability catastrophe (imperative to fix before launch)

Nielsen’s 10 Usability Heuristics Audit Start

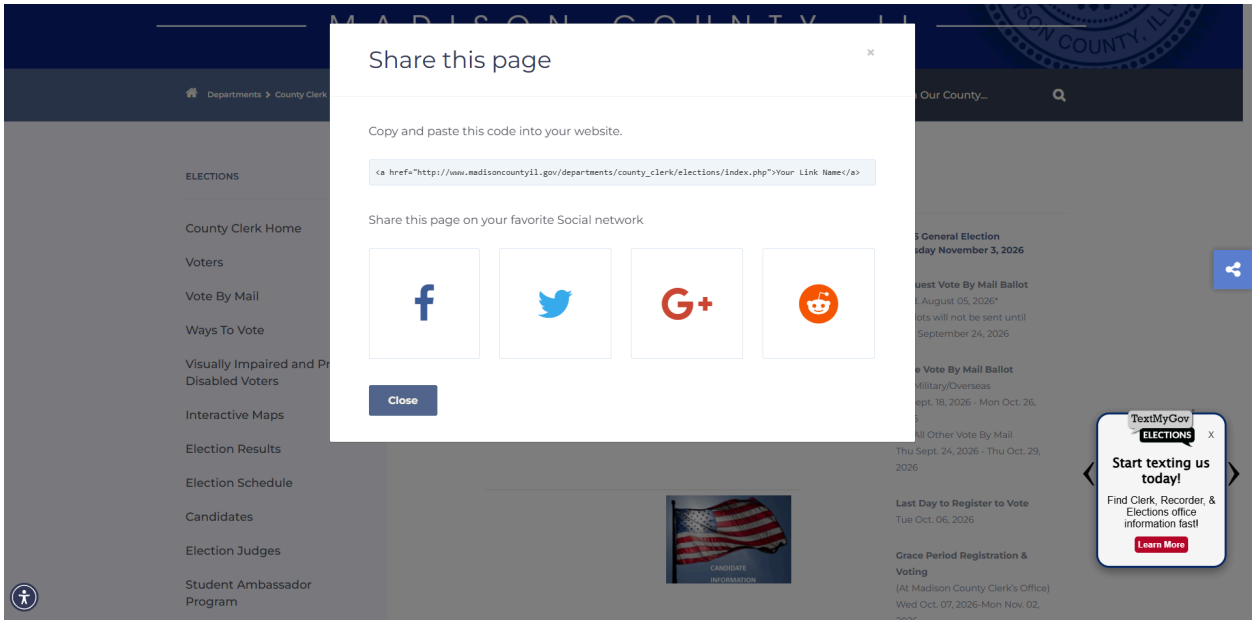








- Last 4 screenshots: Multiple hidden dropdown menus on left sidebar
- Heuristic 6, Severity Rating: 3



- Share button on right (blue square with white icon) opens this page, seemingly little use for most users as they could just copy and paste the link from their web browser. Extra clutter.
- Heuristic 8, Severity Rating: 2



- This automatically popping up on the bottom right seems like extra clutter
- Heuristic 8, Severity Rating: 2



Please CLICK on PICTURE for Information

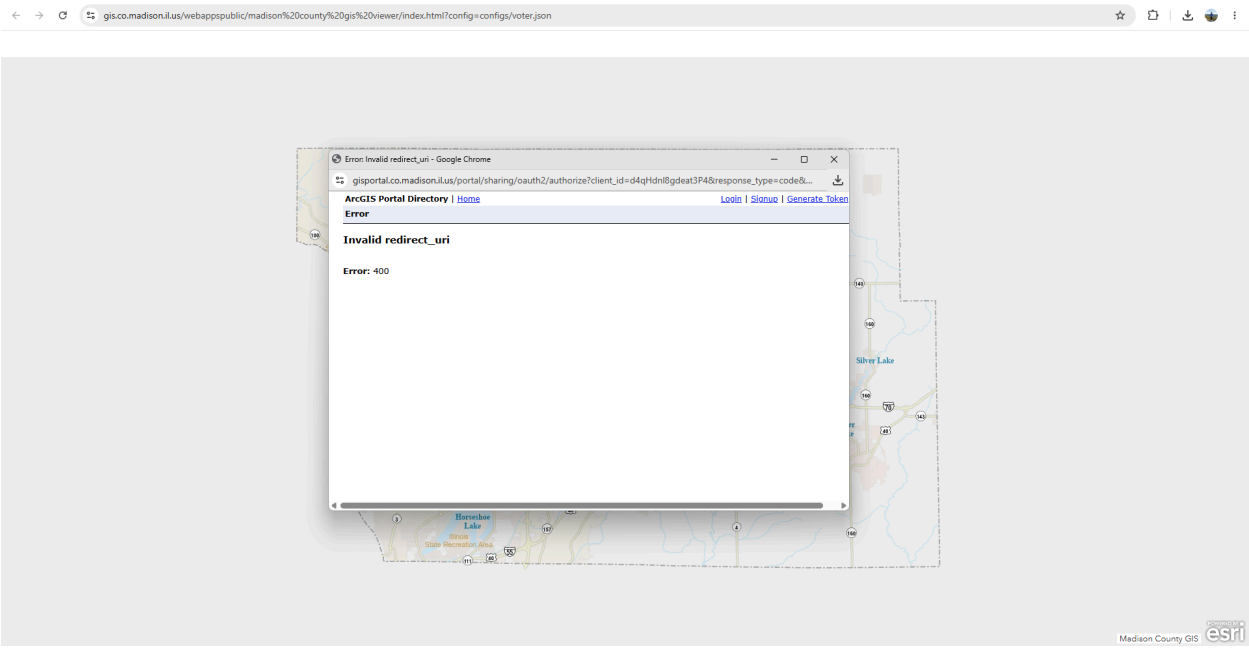




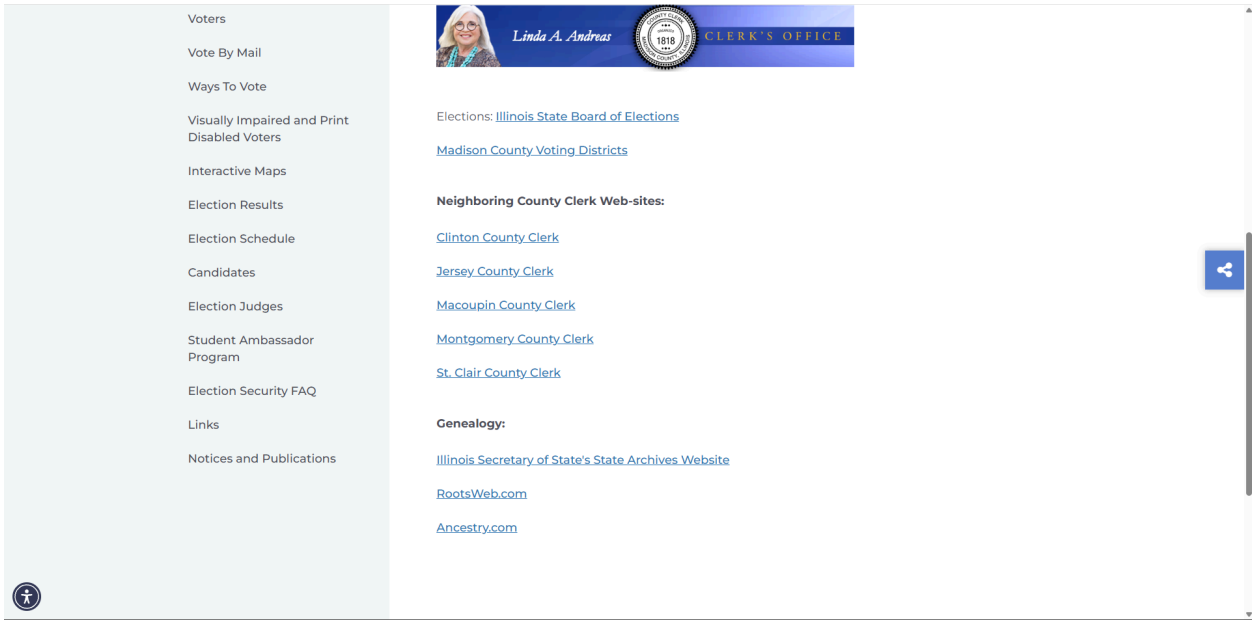




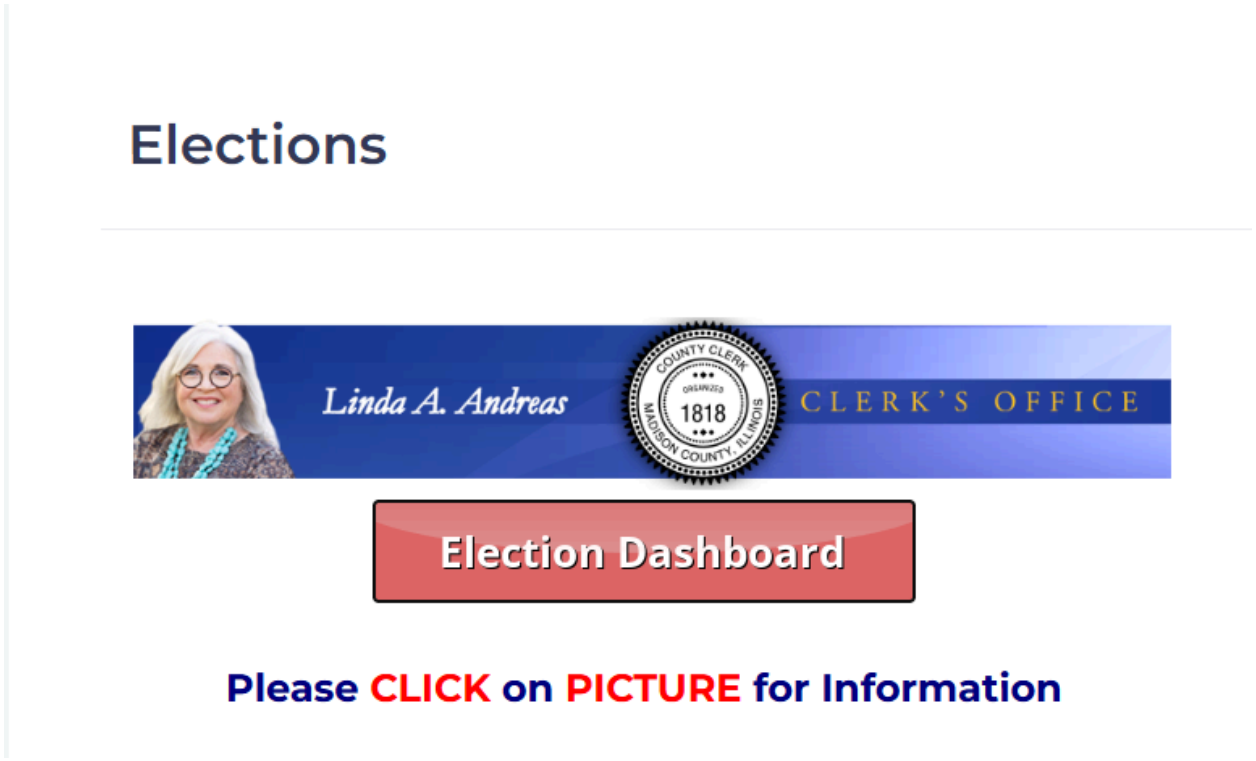
- Pictures as hyperlinks in the center of the page, in weird formation
- Heuristics 4 and 8, Severity Rating: 3

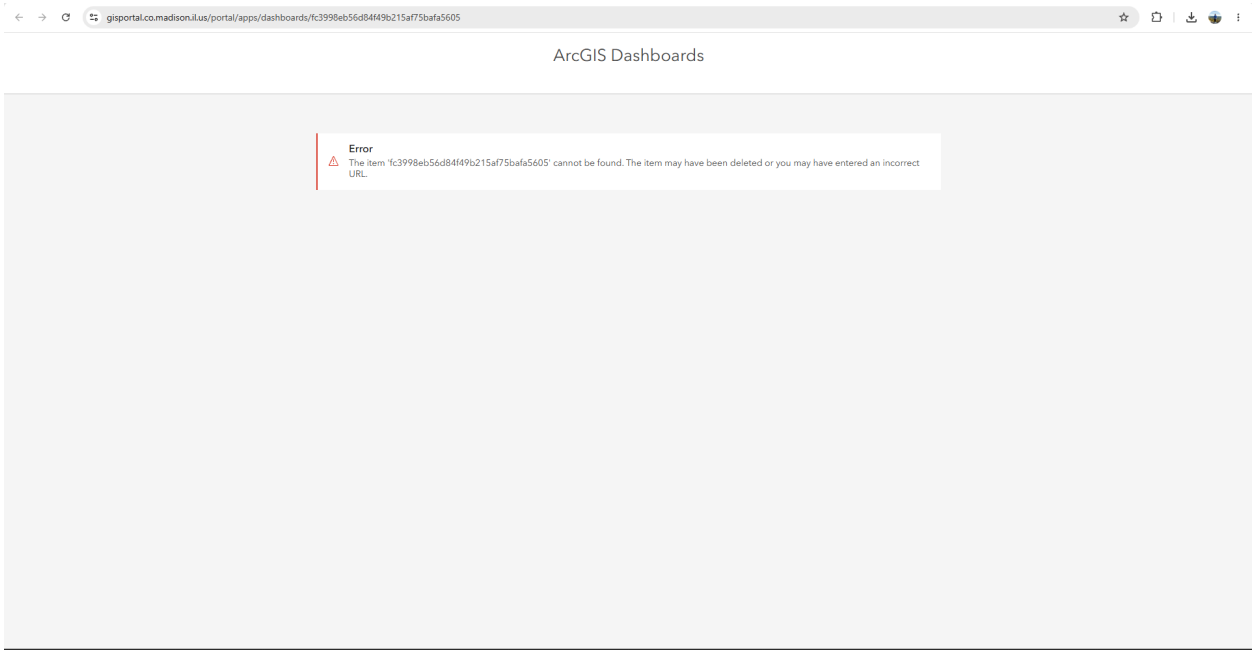


- Unexplained error message on “Voting Districts” interactive map
- Heuristic 9, Severity Rating: 4



- On the “Links” page, they have links to neighboring county clerk websites and third party genealogy companies’ websites. Seems like extra clutter for no reason. This whole “Links” page could probably be deleted.
- Heuristic 8, Severiting Rating: 2





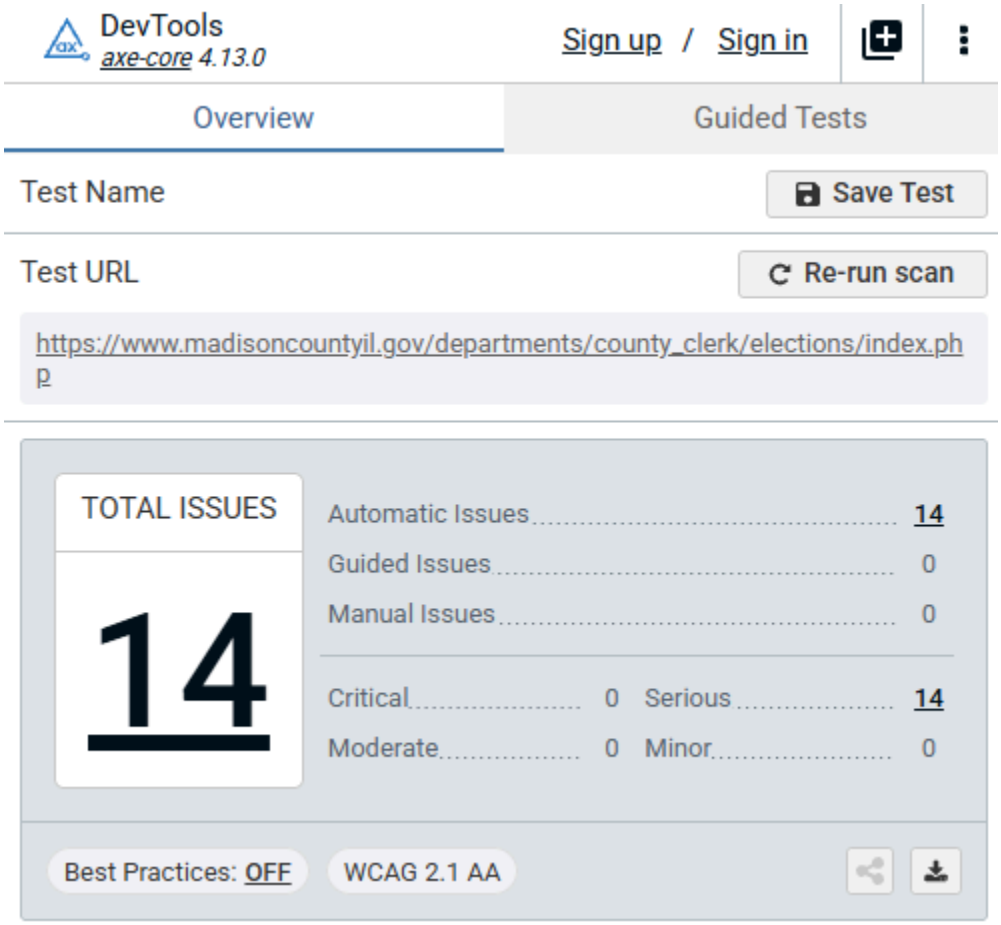
- Last two screenshots: the big, red “Election Dashboard” link takes you to an ArcGIS page with a random error. Useless to the user.
- Heuristic 9, Severity Rating: 4

Baseline Accessibility (WCAG 2.1 AA) Audit

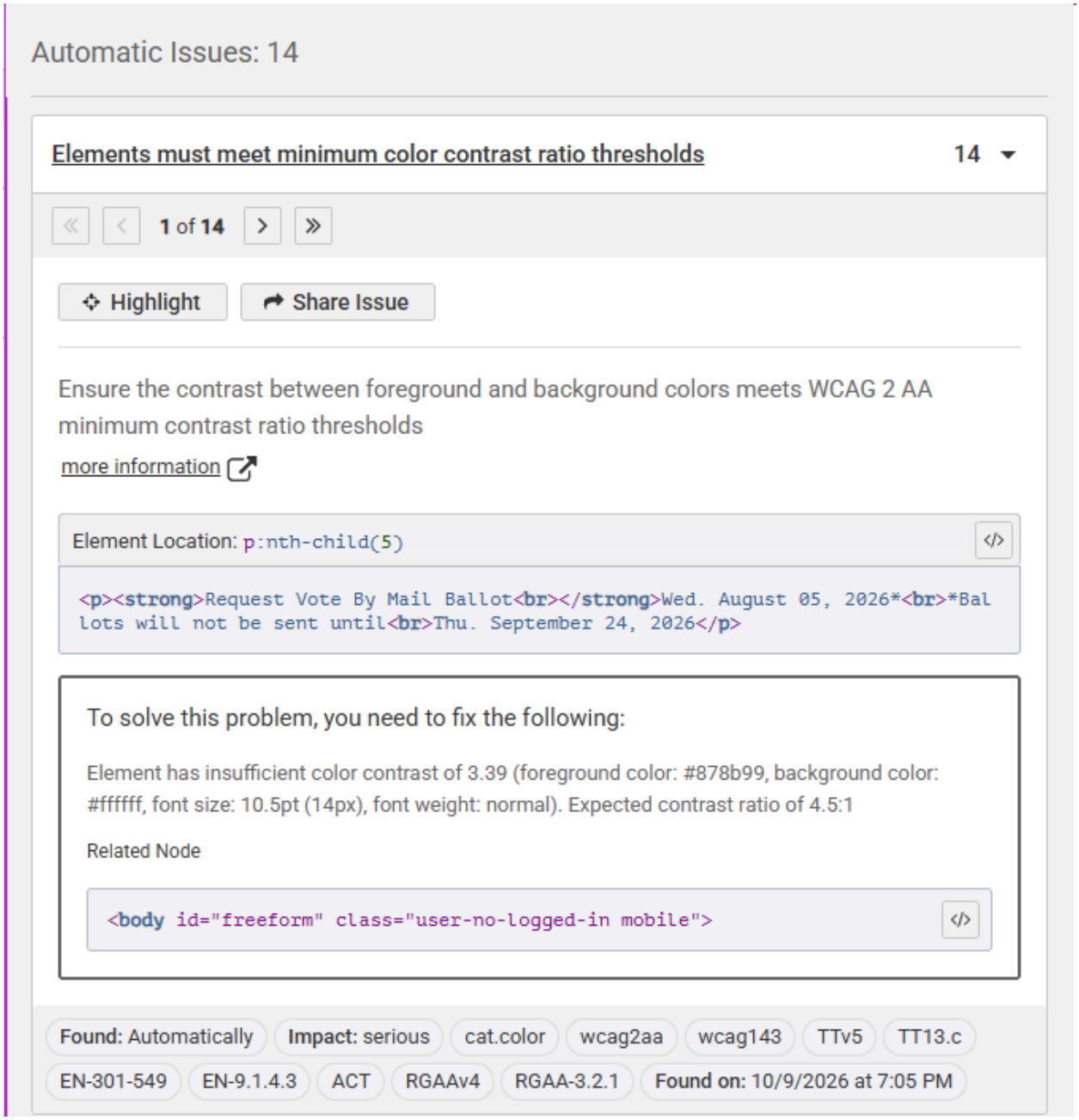
- In this audit, I will be screening the system for critical accessibility barriers. I will first use an automated browser extension to makes checks (axe DevTools) and then subsequently also do my own manual checks.

axe DevTools Check

- The automated check found 14 “Serious” issues, all of which being “Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds



- Here are some examples:



Automatic Issues: 14

Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds 14

« ‹ 2 of 14 › »

Highlight | Share Issue

Ensure the contrast between foreground and background colors meets WCAG 2 AA minimum contrast ratio thresholds

more information

Element Location: `p:nth-child(5) > strong`

```
<strong>Request Vote By Mail Ballot<br></strong>
```

To solve this problem, you need to fix the following:

Element has insufficient color contrast of 3.39 (foreground color: #878b99, background color: #ffffff, font size: 10.5pt (14px), font weight: bold). Expected contrast ratio of 4.5:1

Related Node

```
<body id="freeform" class="user-no-logged-in mobile">
```

Found: Automatically | **Impact:** serious | cat.color | wcag2aa | wcag143 | TTv5 | TT13.c | EN-301-549 | EN-9.1.4.3 | ACT | RGAAv4 | RGAA-3.2.1 | **Found on:** 10/9/2026 at 7:05 PM

Automatic Issues: 14

Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds 14

« ‹ **3** of **14** › »

Next Issue

Highlight | Share Issue

Ensure the contrast between foreground and background colors meets WCAG 2 AA minimum contrast ratio thresholds

more information

Element Location: `p:nth-child(6)`

```
<p><strong>Issue Vote By Mail Ballot<br></strong>For Military/Overseas<br>Fri Se
pt. 18, 2026 - Mon Oct. 26, 2026<br>For All Other Vote By Mail<br>Thu Sept. 24,
2026 - Thu Oct. 29, 2026</p>
```

To solve this problem, you need to fix the following:

Element has insufficient color contrast of 3.39 (foreground color: #878b99, background color: #ffffff, font size: 10.5pt (14px), font weight: normal). Expected contrast ratio of 4.5:1

Related Node

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<body id="freeform" class="user-no-logged-in mobile">
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Automatic Issues: 14

Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds 14

« ‹ **4** of **14** › »

Highlight | Share Issue

Ensure the contrast between foreground and background colors meets WCAG 2 AA minimum contrast ratio thresholds

more information

Element Location: `p:nth-child(6) > strong`

```
<strong>Issue Vote By Mail Ballot<br></strong>
```

To solve this problem, you need to fix the following:

Element has insufficient color contrast of 3.39 (foreground color: #878b99, background color: #ffffff, font size: 10.5pt (14px), font weight: bold). Expected contrast ratio of 4.5:1

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Automatic Issues: 14

Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds 14

« ‹ **5** of **14** › »

Highlight | Share Issue

Ensure the contrast between foreground and background colors meets WCAG 2 AA minimum contrast ratio thresholds

more information

Element Location: `p:nth-child(7)`

```
<p><strong>Last Day to Register to Vote<br></strong>Tue Oct. 06, 2026</p>
```

To solve this problem, you need to fix the following:

Element has insufficient color contrast of 3.39 (foreground color: #878b99, background color: #ffffff, font size: 10.5pt (14px), font weight: normal). Expected contrast ratio of 4.5:1

Related Node

```
<body id="freeform" class="user-no-logged-in mobile">
```

Found: Automatically | **Impact:** serious | cat.color | wcag2aa | wcag143 | TTv5 | TT13.c | EN-301-549 | EN-9.1.4.3 | ACT | RGAAv4 | RGAA-3.2.1 | **Found on:** 10/9/2026 at 7:05 PM

Automatic Issues: 14

Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds 14

« ‹ 6 of 14 › »

Highlight | Share Issue

Ensure the contrast between foreground and background colors meets WCAG 2 AA minimum contrast ratio thresholds

more information

Element Location: `p:nth-child(7) > strong`

```
<strong>Last Day to Register to Vote<br></strong>
```

To solve this problem, you need to fix the following:

Element has insufficient color contrast of 3.39 (foreground color: #878b99, background color: #ffffff, font size: 10.5pt (14px), font weight: bold). Expected contrast ratio of 4.5:1

Related Node

```
<body id="freeform" class="user-no-logged-in mobile">
```

Found: Automatically | **Impact:** serious | cat.color | wcag2aa | wcag143 | TTv5 | TT13.c | EN-301-549 | EN-9.1.4.3 | ACT | RGAAv4 | RGAA-3.2.1 | **Found on:** 10/9/2026 at 7:05 PM

Automatic Issues: 14

Elements must meet minimum color contrast ratio thresholds 14

« ‹ **7** of **14** › »

Highlight | Share Issue

Ensure the contrast between foreground and background colors meets WCAG 2 AA minimum contrast ratio thresholds

more information

Element Location: `p:nth-child(8)`

```
<p><strong>Grace Period Registration &amp;amp; Voting<br></strong>(At Madison County
 Clerk's Office)<br>Wed Oct. 07, 2026-Mon Nov. 02, 2026</p>
```

To solve this problem, you need to fix the following:

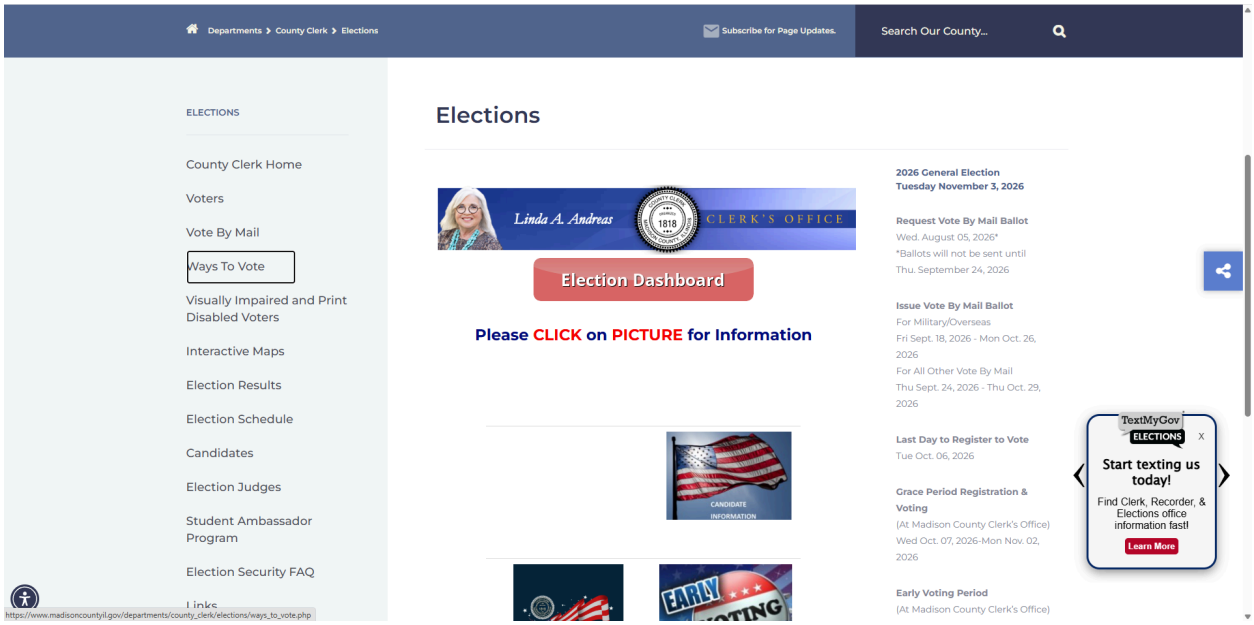
Element has insufficient color contrast of 3.39 (foreground color: #878b99, background color: #ffffff, font size: 10.5pt (14px), font weight: normal). Expected contrast ratio of 4.5:1

Related Node

```
<body id="freeform" class="user-no-logged-in mobile">
```

Found: Automatically | **Impact:** serious | cat.color | wcag2aa | wcag143 | TTv5 | TT13.c | EN-301-549 | EN-9.1.4.3 | ACT | RGAAv4 | RGAA-3.2.1 | **Found on:** 10/9/2026 at 7:05 PM

Manual Check



- You are able to navigate the site without a mouse by repeatedly pressing the tab button to systematically go through the hyperlinks. See in above photo that “Ways To Vote” is highlighted and was done so without the use of a mouse.





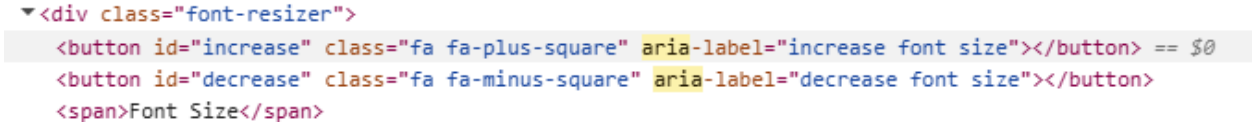
- It even highlights the photos containing links, although I will say that being able to see that they are highlighted is a little hard even for me with relatively good eyesight. Above you can see highlighted (left) vs not highlighted (right)

- I will note that when pressing tab to highlight things, the third party accessibility settings in the bottom left is the very last thing highlighted. I counted and it takes approximately 70 tab presses to highlight the accessibility settings without a mouse. Seems like a gross oversight.



- They seem to be using good semantic HTML and not creating endless div soup





- There are 41 instances of “aria” in the HTML code. Seems like they are doing a good job with screen reader support at least.